

ValuePics - How To Guide

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ValuePics keeps item records, photos, values, notes, backups, and reports on your device. Use this guide when you want to add items quickly, organize collections, or export something you can share or print.

1. Start Here

- The main list shows your saved records and totals.
- Use `+ Add Item` to create a new record.
- Use Search to find records across names, notes, tags, collections, and lookup text.
- Your data stays on the device until you export or back it up.

2. Add a New Record

- Tap `+`, then choose `Camera` or `Gallery`.
- After the image loads, enter the item name and description.
- Choose a category before saving.
- Use `Save` to store one record or `Save + Add Another` for batch entry.
- If the gallery picker closes without a selection, choose it again from the add menu.
- On larger screens, the item-name field has an `X` button to clear a bad auto-fill.
- On smaller phones, tap the item-name field once to select all text, then start typing to replace it.

3. Category Rules and Bills

- New records must have a category before they can be saved.
- Tap the category field to pick an existing category or add a new one.
- Choose `None` only if you truly want an uncategorized record.
- `Bills` is a special category in Personal mode.
- In Insurance mode, `Bills` is hidden from the picker.
- Bills records keep one stored amount and can be viewed as weekly, monthly, or yearly.
- Bills categories are protected from rename and delete actions.

4. Use Auto-Lookup Well

- Lookup can fill the item name or description from image analysis and web results.
- Review the auto-filled text before saving so you do not keep a bad match.
- If auto-lookup suggests a wrong title, clear it on a large screen or select-all and type over it on a small screen.
- If the item name is already meaningful, the app leaves it alone.

5. Search, Filters, and Sorting

- Search scans names, descriptions, collections, tags, notes, and lookup text.
- Combine collection and tag filters to narrow large libraries.
- Sort by newest, oldest, value high, value low, name A-Z, or duplicate-finding views.
- Clear filters when you want totals for the full library again.

6. Open a Record

- Tap any card to open the full detail screen.
- Review the image, value source, notes, and related metadata.
- Use the edit controls to revise the record later.
- Open source URLs when they are available and useful.

7. Edit Details

- Edit the item name, description, collection, tags, notes, and estimated value.
- Save after each change if you want to keep it immediately.
- Use the on-screen clear `X` buttons where they appear to remove bad text quickly.
- When you change a collection, the record updates everywhere it is used.

8. Photos and Audio

- Records can hold multiple photos plus one cover photo.
- Add more photos from camera or gallery from the detail screen.
- Set the best image as the cover so list cards look right.
- Audio notes are optional and are stored per record.
- Deleting the cover photo promotes the next remaining photo automatically.

9. Notes and Will Instructions

- Standard notes are always available.
- Personal notes can be hidden behind the app's unlock flow.
- Will instructions can be written per item when you want export-ready estate notes.
- Use clear language in will instructions so the PDF stays readable.

10. Collections, Tabs, and Tags

- Manage Collections lets you add, rename, or delete collection labels.
- Manage Tabs helps you keep the top-level navigation tidy.
- Tags support up to 6 comma-separated values.
- Use short, consistent collection names so filters are easier to scan.
- Collection names are normalized so duplicates with different spacing do not slip through.

11. Selection Mode

- Start selection mode from the organization tools or by long-pressing a card.
- Tap records to select or clear them.
- The selected count appears in the top bar.
- Selection mode is useful for delete, export, and other bulk actions.

12. Export and PDF Reports

- Export summary PDFs when you want a shareable report of a collection or filtered set.
- Choose the text-only version when you want speed.
- Choose the version with photos when you want a richer handout.
- Export warnings explain when photos are missing or no items are eligible.

- Progress dialogs show what the app is doing while the PDF is generated.
- The in-app How To PDF you are reading is generated from the same markdown source.

13. Backup, Restore, and Merge

- Use Backup before large changes, migrations, or device resets.
- Backup creates a ZIP with records, photos, metadata, and audio notes.
- Restore replaces the current data with the backup you choose.
- Merge combines imported data into the existing database.
- Auto-backup slots rotate so you can recover from a bad restore.

14. Appearance, Help, and About

- Use theme settings to follow the system theme or force light/dark.
- Open How To from the help menu whenever you want this guide again.
- The About screen shows version, storage, backup information, and unlock options.
- Sample data tools help you explore the app without touching your own records.

15. Practical Tips

- Keep one collection naming style across the app.
- Use tags for cross-cutting labels such as repair, inheritance, or warranty.
- Verify large value estimates with an external source.
- Record the item name as soon as possible while it is still in front of you.
- If a screen feels cramped on a small phone, the app hides some helper controls and lets you select text by tapping the field.
- Back up before you experiment with merge, restore, or bulk delete actions.

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Dedicated to my beautiful wife Carmen.